TOPIC 04 · PHASE DIAGRAMS

Phase Diagrams and Solidification

Phases and microconstituents, one-component and binary isomorphous diagrams, the Gibbs phase rule, the tie line and the lever rule, non-equilibrium solidification and binary eutectic systems.

Source: Universidad Carlos III de Madrid · Session 7 T4 Phase diagrams I_2025.pdf

Central idea: a phase diagram is a map that tells which phases are stable in a material for each temperature, pressure and composition. Reading it gives three answers for any alloy at any temperature: which phases are present, what each phase is made of, and how much of each there is.

This page follows the official slides of Topic 4 in order. Part I (Session 7) covers the basic vocabulary, one-component diagrams, binary isomorphous systems, the Gibbs phase rule, the tie line and the lever rule, non-equilibrium solidification and binary eutectic systems. Worked examples use only data printed on the slides.

Part I — Phase diagrams I (Session 7)

§ 1 Component, phase and microconstituent [Session 7 Slide 2]

Three words are used all through the topic, and they mean different things:

- **Component:** a chemical substance or compound with a fixed composition that can form part of a phase or of an alloy. Examples: aluminium (Al), alumina (Al_2O_3).
- **Phase:** a chemically and structurally homogeneous region that forms part of the microstructure. It can be made of one or of several components. Examples: ferrite (a solid solution of C in Fe with BCC structure), austenite (a solid solution of C in Fe with FCC structure), calcium carbonate ($CaCO_3$).
- **Microconstituent:** each of the different structures that can be seen on a polished surface of the material. It can be made of one phase or of several phases.

The slide illustrates the three words with food: the components of a potato are water, protein, fat, carbohydrates and so on (a table of grams per 100 g); the potato itself plays the role of a phase; and fries, a structure you can see and that is made from the potato, play the role of a microconstituent.

In a real material, the micrograph below shows a steel with two microconstituents. Region 1 is **ferrite**, a single phase. Regions 2 and 3 are **pearlite**, a microconstituent made of two phases (ferrite and cementite) arranged in thin alternating plates.



Micrograph of a steel with ferrite and pearlite

Figure 1. Microconstituents in a steel: 1 is ferrite, 2 and 3 are pearlite (ferrite + cementite). From Session 7 Slide 2.

§ 2 The equilibrium phase diagram [Session 7 Slide 3]

An **equilibrium phase diagram** (also called a **stability map**) is a map of the phases in thermodynamic equilibrium that are present in a system of materials at different pressures, temperatures and compositions.

The slide uses the phase diagram of CO_2 as an example:

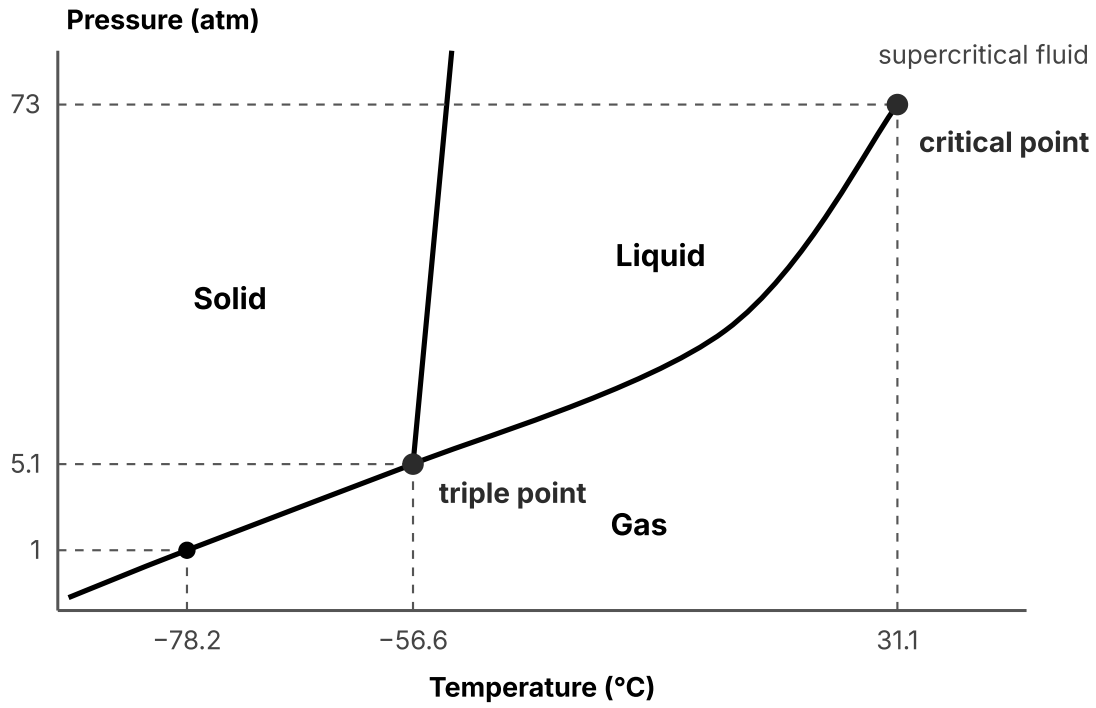


Figure 2. Phase diagram of CO_2 (axes not to scale): triple point at 5.1 atm and −56.6 °C, sublimation at 1 atm and −78.2 °C, critical point at 73 atm and 31.1 °C. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 3.

- There is no liquid CO_2 at room temperature and ambient pressure.
- The slope of the solid-liquid line, dP/dT, is positive, as it is in almost all substances.
- At the **triple point** (5.1 atm, −56.6 °C) gas, liquid and solid are in equilibrium.
- At temperatures below the triple point CO_2 can sublime: gas → solid (dry ice) on cooling, and solid → gas on heating.
- Above the critical temperature T_c = 31.1 °C and pressure P_c = 73 atm CO_2 is a **supercritical fluid** (used to extract caffeine from coffee).

WORKED EXAMPLE 1 — WHY DRY ICE DOES NOT MELT AT 1 ATM

Question. A block of solid CO_2 is heated at a constant pressure of 1 atm. What phases appear?

Reading the diagram. Follow the horizontal line P = 1 atm from left to right. Since 1 atm is below the pressure of the triple point (5.1 atm), the line never enters the liquid region: it goes from the solid region straight into the gas region, crossing the sublimation line at −78.2 °C.

Answer. The solid turns directly into gas at −78.2 °C (sublimation). Liquid CO_2 can exist only at pressures above 5.1 atm, which is why there is no liquid CO_2 at room conditions [Session 7 Slide 3].

§ 3 Unary (one-component) diagrams [Session 7 Slides 5-6]

With a single component the composition is fixed, so the diagram is drawn with **pressure and temperature** as axes (a P-T diagram).

3.1 Water [Session 7 Slide 5]

The P-T diagram of water has three lines that meet at the **triple point** P_T: the sublimation line (A to P_T), the melting line (P_T to B) and the vaporisation line (P_T to C). Cooling at constant pressure along the dashed line, the water vapour first crosses the vaporisation line at T_v and then the melting line at T_m.

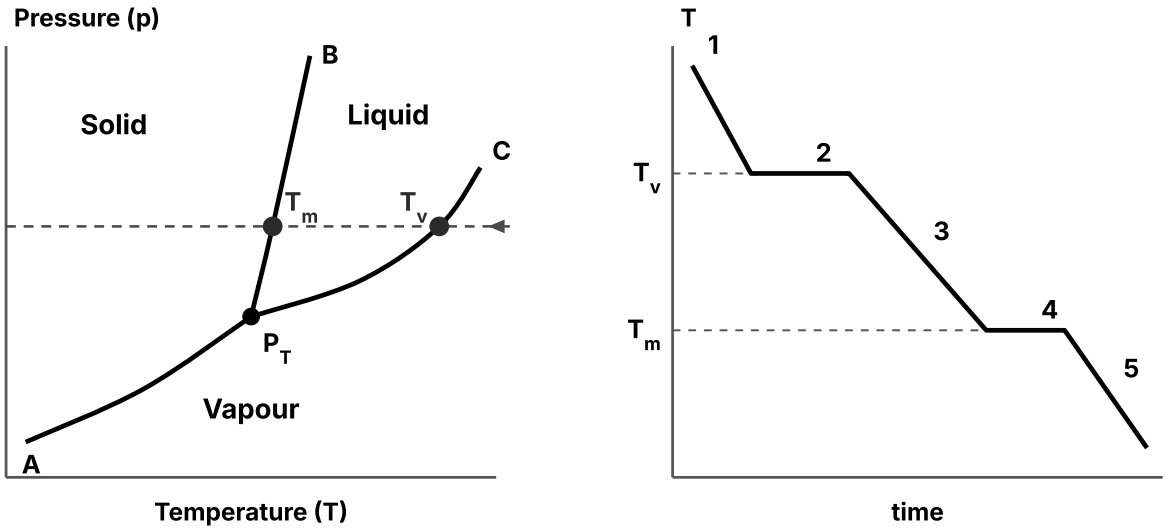


Figure 3. Left: P-T diagram of water with the sublimation (A to P_T), melting (P_T to B) and vaporisation (P_T to C) lines and the triple point P_T; cooling along the dashed line at constant pressure crosses the vaporisation line at T_v and the melting line at T_m. Right: the cooling curve, with a plateau at each transition (2: condensation, 4: solidification). Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 5.

The **cooling curve** on the right records the temperature against time along that path. In the stretches 1, 3 and 5 a single phase cools down. In the plateaus 2 (condensation at T_v) and 4 (solidification at T_m) the temperature stays constant while two phases coexist, because the heat released by the transformation compensates the heat that is lost.

On a diagram with pressure on a log scale, the vertical line at 1 atm meets the melting line at 0 °C (water/ice) and the vaporisation line at 100 °C (steam/water):

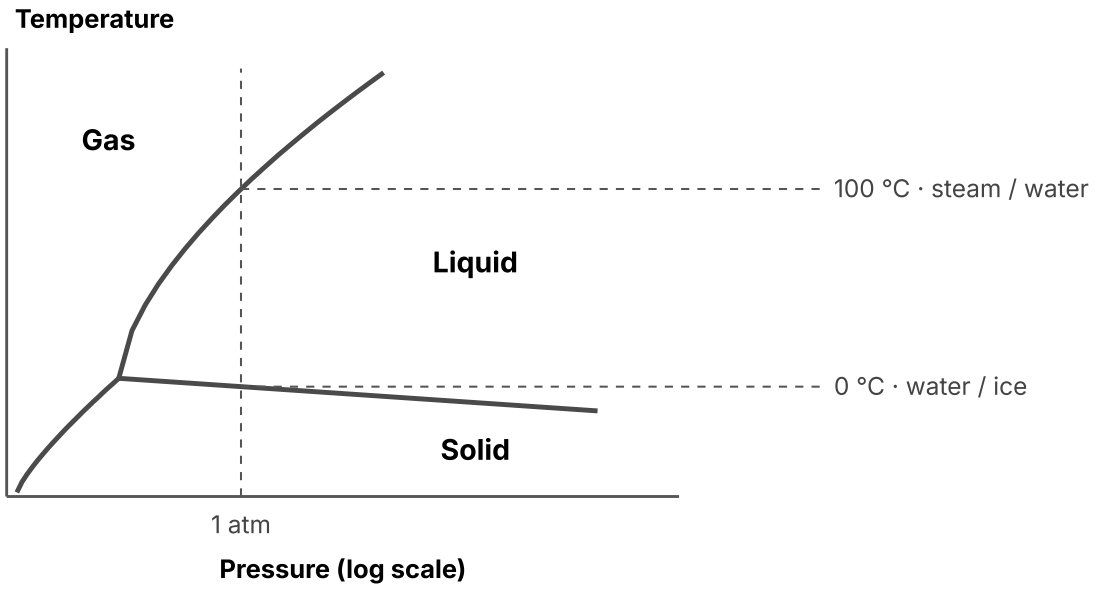


Figure 4. Temperature against pressure (log scale) for water: at 1 atm the vertical line meets the melting line at 0 °C and the vaporisation line at 100 °C. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 5.

At very high pressures (up to several GPa) water has many different solid phases, the different crystal structures of ice:

Phase diagram of water up to 4 GPa

Figure 5. Water at high pressure (up to 4 GPa): several crystal structures of ice (I, II, III, V, VI, VII, VIII), each a different solid phase. From Session 7 Slide 5.

3.2 Pure iron [Session 7 Slide 6]

Solid iron has **three different crystal structures**, each a different phase: **α-Fe (BCC)** below 910 °C, **γ-Fe (FCC)** between 910 and 1394 °C, and **δ-Fe (BCC)** from 1394 °C up to the melting point, 1538 °C. Different phases coexist at the **triple points**. The slide compares the three solid structures with three varieties of potato (yellow, red and purple) and the liquid with potato purée: the same "substance" in different forms.

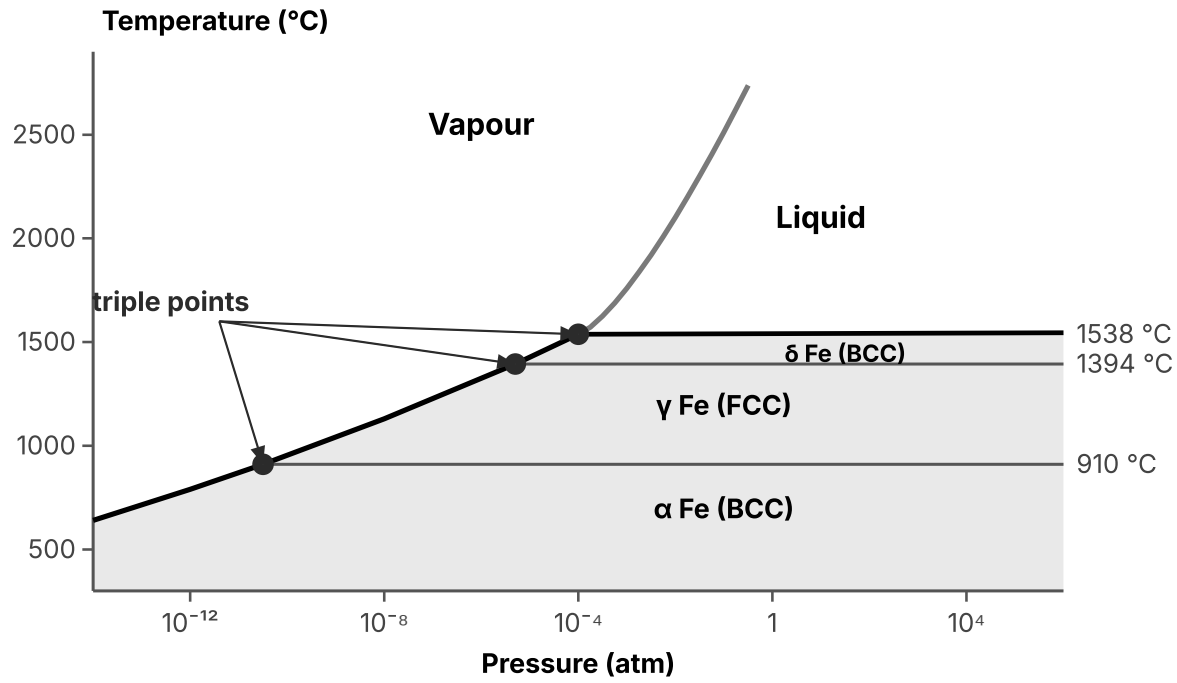


Figure 6. P-T diagram of pure iron (pressure on a log scale): three solid phases, α (BCC) below 910 °C, γ (FCC) between 910 and 1394 °C and δ (BCC) up to the melting point, 1538 °C; at each triple point three phases coexist. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 6.

§ 4 Binary isomorphous diagrams [Session 7 Slides 8-11]

4.1 Cooling curves [Session 7 Slide 8]

Cooling curves are used to determine the temperatures of the phase transitions: the temperature of a cooling molten metal is recorded against time and plotted.

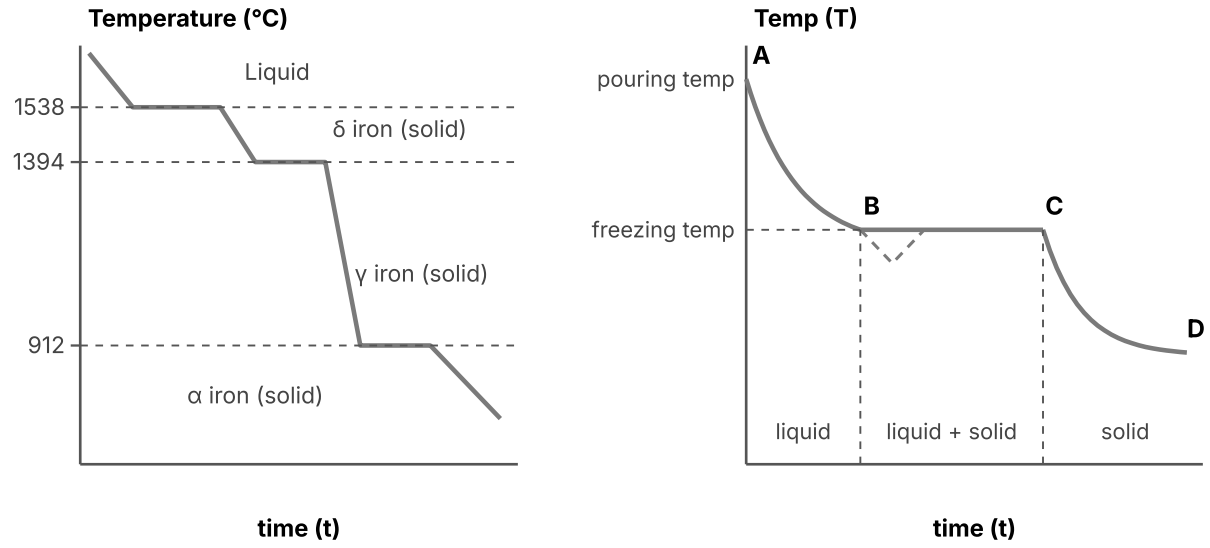


Figure 7. Left: cooling curve of pure iron, with a thermal arrest at each transition (1538, 1394 and 912 °C). Right: cooling curve of a pure metal: A to B cooling of the liquid, B solidification begins (after a small undercooling, dashed), C solidification ends, C to D cooling of the solid. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 8.

- **Thermal arrest:** while a pure metal solidifies, the heat lost to the surroundings equals the heat supplied by the solidifying metal, so the temperature stays constant (a plateau). Pure iron shows one plateau for solidification and one for each change of crystal structure. (This slide prints 912 °C for the γ → α change; Slide 6 prints 910 °C.)
- **Alloys** solidify over a range of temperatures: they show no thermal arrest, only changes of slope.

4.2 Building the diagram from cooling curves [Session 7 Slide 9]

A **binary isomorphous** system has two components with **complete solid solubility**. Its diagram is built from the cooling curves of several compositions: each curve gives the temperature where solidification starts and the one where it ends. Joining the start points gives the **liquidus**; joining the end points gives the **solidus**. Above the liquidus everything is liquid (L), below the solidus everything is a single solid solution (SS), and between them liquid and solid coexist (L + SS).

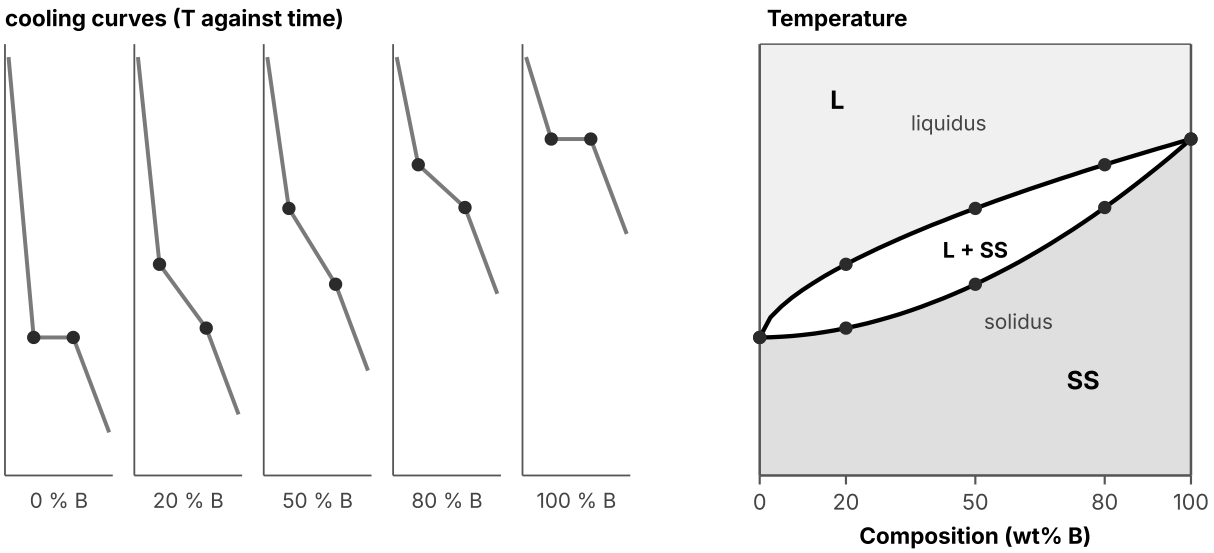


Figure 8. Each cooling curve gives the temperature where solidification starts (a point of the liquidus) and where it ends (a point of the solidus); the pure components (0 and 100 % B) solidify at a single temperature. Joining the points gives the diagram with the regions L, L + SS and SS. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 9.

The slide compares the series of compositions with milk: whole, semi-skimmed and skimmed milk are mixtures of water and skim solids in different proportions, just as the alloys are mixtures of A and B.

4.3 Microstructure along the cooling [Session 7 Slide 10]

For an alloy of a given composition (the vertical line), the diagram tells what the microstructure is at each temperature:

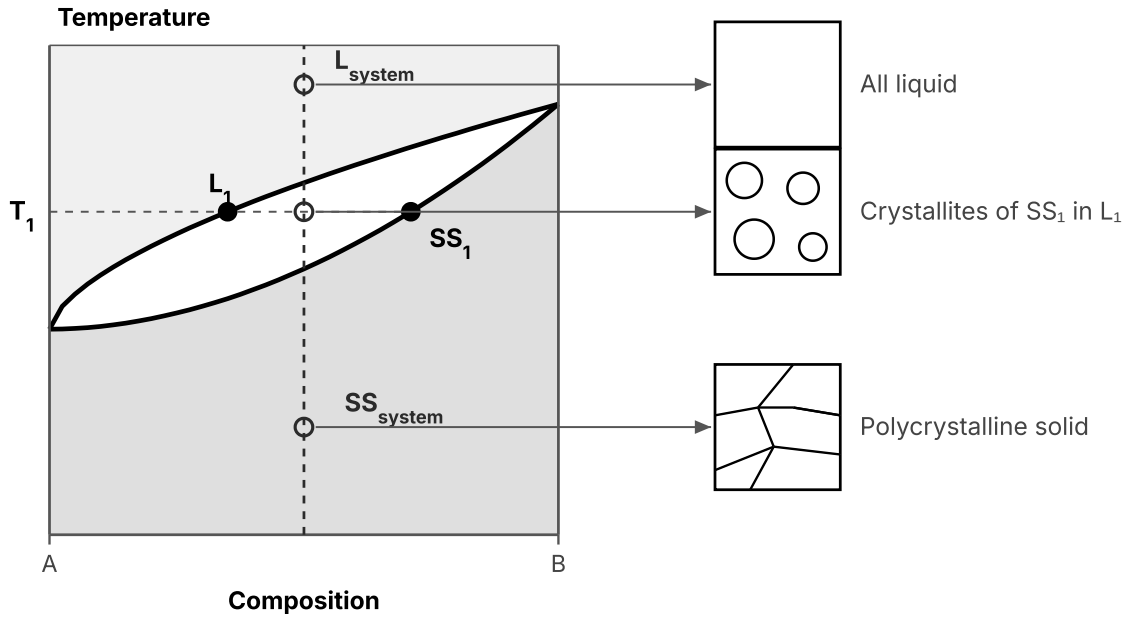


Figure 9. An alloy cooled through the isomorphous diagram: all liquid above the liquidus, crystallites of solid solution SS_1 in a liquid L_1 at T_1, and a polycrystalline single-phase solid below the solidus. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 10.

- above the liquidus: **all liquid**;
- at a temperature T_1 between the liquidus and the solidus: **crystallites of the solid solution SS_1 in a matrix of liquid L_1**; the compositions of L_1 and SS_1 are read on the liquidus and the solidus at T_1;
- below the solidus: a **polycrystalline solid** of a single phase, the solid solution, with the composition of the alloy.

The slide's analogy: milk alone is the liquid; milk with pieces of Manchego cheese is the two-phase mixture; the cheese alone is the solid.

4.4 Complete solid solubility [Session 7 Slide 11]

With complete solubility in the solid state:

- the material is a **polycrystalline single-phase** material: its microstructure (FCC, BCC or any other) is not different from that of the pure metal, because the atoms of B simply replace atoms of A in the same lattice;
- when solute is added, the melting temperature T_m is modified;
- the alloy **does not solidify at a constant temperature** but over a range of temperatures, between the liquidus and the solidus.

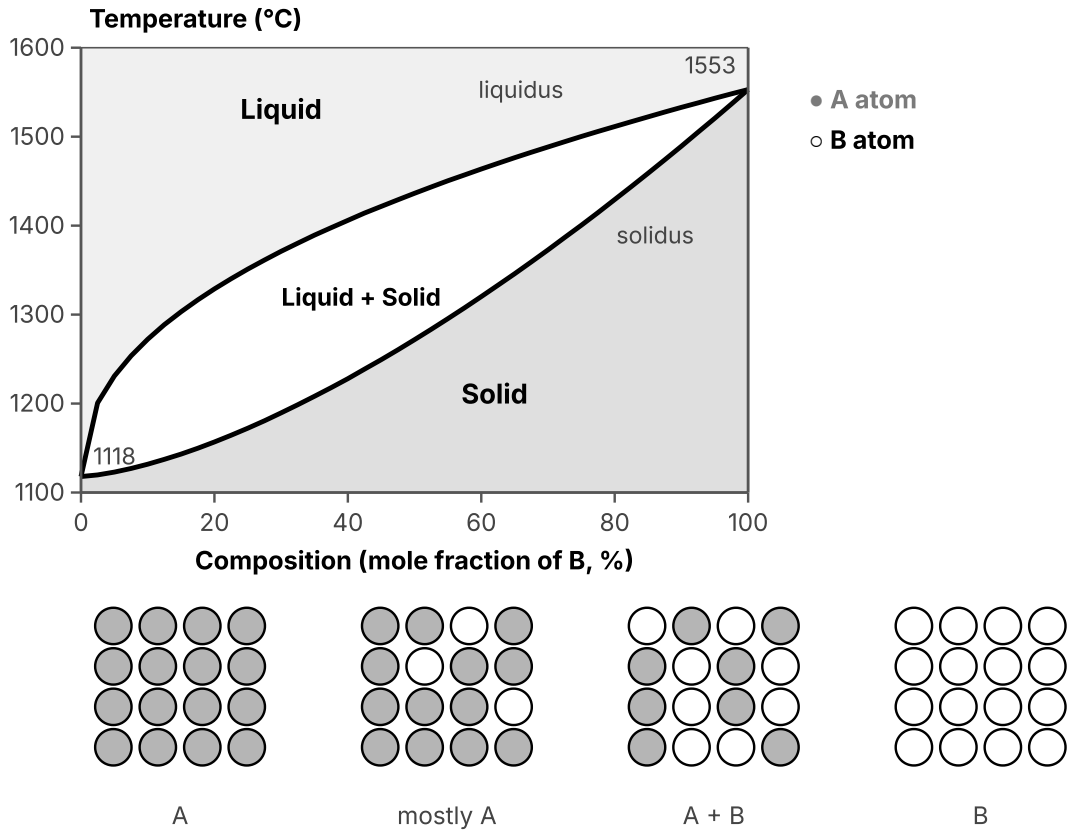


Figure 10. Isomorphous system with complete solid solubility, from the melting point of A (1118 °C) to that of B (1553 °C): B atoms replace A atoms in the same crystal lattice at any proportion, so the solid is a single phase, and the alloys solidify over a range of temperatures. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 11.

§ 5 Gibbs phase rule [Session 7 Slide 13]

The **Gibbs phase rule** counts how many variables can be changed independently while keeping the same phases in equilibrium:

$$F = C - P + N$$

- F: degrees of freedom, the number of independent variables available to the system;
- C: number of components;
- P: number of phases;
- N: number of non-compositional variables (for example pressure and temperature).

With pressure and temperature both free, $N = 2$ and $F = C - P + 2$. For routine processing of materials the pressure can be considered fixed at 1 atm, so only temperature remains and

$$F = C - P + 1$$

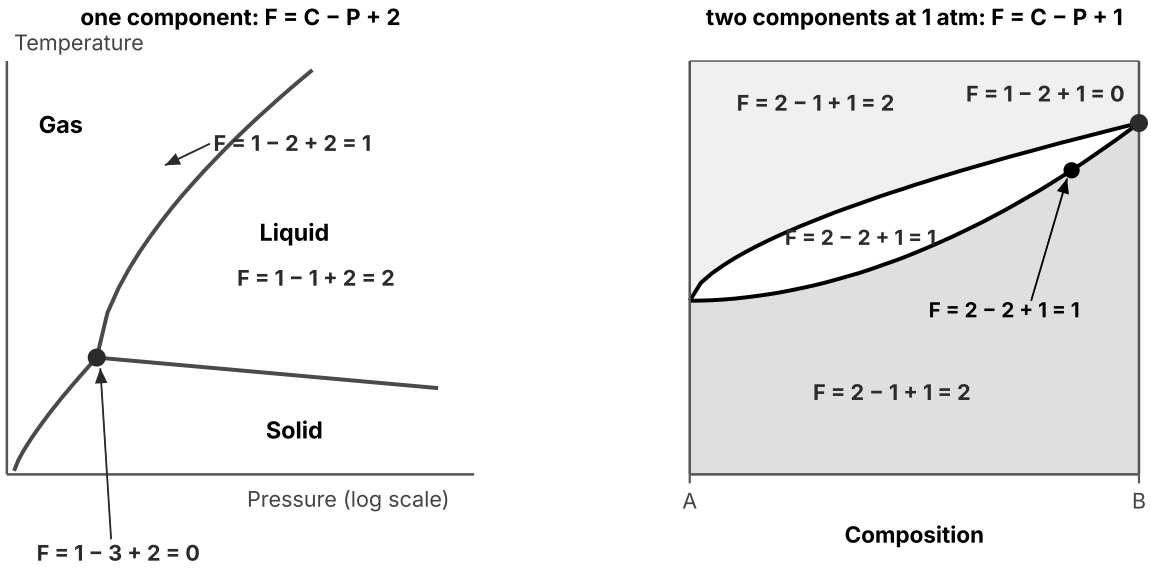


Figure 11. Degrees of freedom from F = C − P + N. Left, one component with pressure and temperature free (N = 2): F = 2 in a single-phase region, 1 on a two-phase line, 0 at the triple point. Right, two components at 1 atm (N = 1): F = 2 in L or in the solid, 1 in L + solid and on its boundaries, 0 at the melting point of a pure component. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 13.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2 — COUNTING DEGREES OF FREEDOM ON THE SLIDE DIAGRAMS

One component (water), $F = 1 - P + 2$ [Session 7 Slide 13]:

- inside a single-phase region (liquid): $F = 1 - 1 + 2 = 2$; temperature and pressure can both change without leaving the region;
- on a two-phase line (for example solid-liquid): $F = 1 - 2 + 2 = 1$; if the temperature is chosen, the pressure is fixed by the line;
- at the triple point: $F = 1 - 3 + 2 = 0$; three phases coexist only at one temperature and one pressure.

Two components at 1 atm, $F = 2 - P + 1$:

- in L or in the solid solution: $F = 2 - 1 + 1 = 2$; temperature and composition can both change;
- in L + solid (and on its boundaries): $F = 2 - 2 + 1 = 1$;
- at the melting point of pure B, a single component with two phases: $F = 1 - 2 + 1 = 0$, which is why a pure metal melts at one fixed temperature.

Consequence for the tie line (§6). In the α + L region of the Cu-Ni diagram $F = 1$. Choosing the temperature uses that single degree of freedom, so the compositions of the two phases are no longer free: at 1250 °C they can only be C_L = 32 wt% Ni and C_α = 43 wt% Ni [Session 7 Slide 16]. Changing the overall composition of the alloy changes only the amounts of the two phases, not their compositions.

§ 6 Tie line and lever rule [Session 7 Slides 15-21]

In a two-phase region two questions are answered with two tools [Session 7 Slide 15]:

- **Phase composition: the tie line.** Draw a horizontal line (constant temperature) through the point of the alloy across the two-phase region. Its intersections with the phase boundaries give, on the composition axis, the composition of each phase.
- **Phase amounts: the lever rule.** The fraction of each phase is computed by taking the length of the tie line from the overall alloy composition to the phase boundary of the **other** phase, and dividing by the total length of the tie line [Session 7 Slide 16].

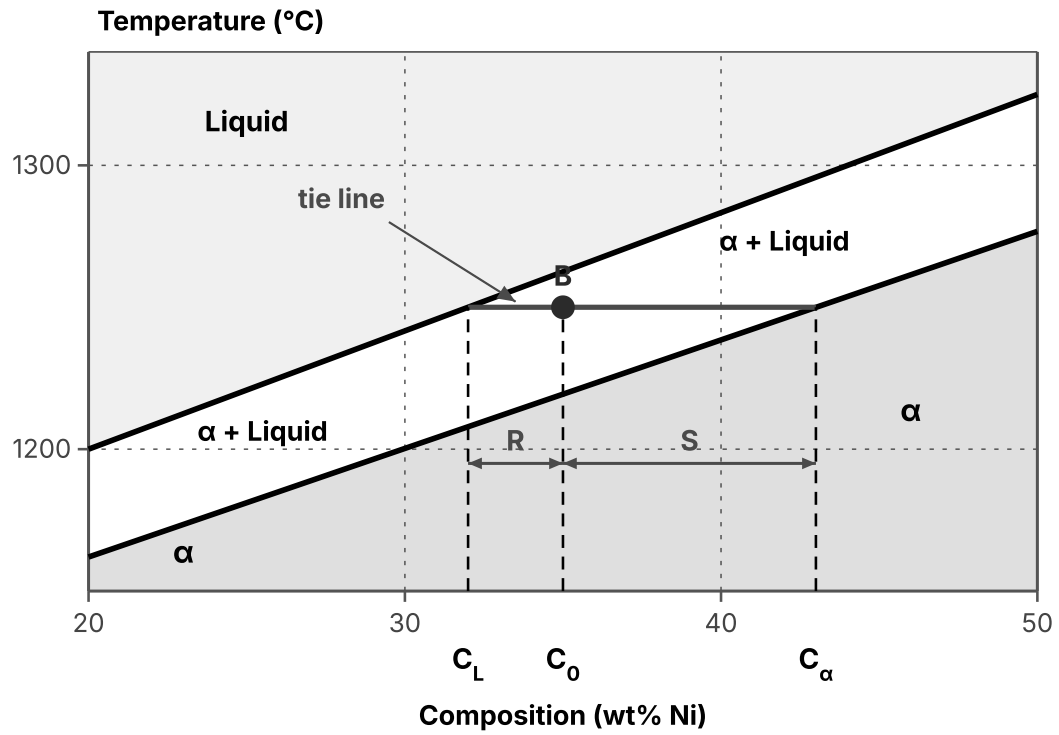


Figure 12. Alloy B, 35 wt% Ni at 1250 °C, in the α + L region of the Cu-Ni diagram. The tie line through B ends on the liquidus at C_L = 32 wt% Ni and on the solidus at C_α = 43 wt% Ni; R and S are the lengths of its two arms. Redrawn from Session 7 Slides 15-21.

For the alloy B, with overall composition C_0 and the arms $R = C_0 - C_L$ and $S = C_\alpha - C_0$:

$$W_L = \frac{S}{R+S} = \frac{C_\alpha - C_0}{C_\alpha - C_L} \qquad W_\alpha = \frac{R}{R+S} = \frac{C_0 - C_L}{C_\alpha - C_L} \qquad W_L + W_\alpha = 1$$

where W_L is the mass fraction of liquid and W_α the mass fraction of α.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3 — CU-35 WT% NI AT 1250 °C [SESSION 7 SLIDES 16-21]

Data from the slide. $C_0 = 35$ wt% Ni at 1250 °C (point B). The tie line meets the liquidus at $C_L = 32$ wt% Ni and the solidus at $C_\alpha = 43$ wt% Ni.

Step 1, the arms of the lever. $R = C_0 - C_L = 35 - 32 = 3$ wt% Ni and $S = C_\alpha - C_0 = 43 - 35 = 8$ wt% Ni; the whole tie line is $R + S = C_\alpha - C_L = 43 - 32 = 11$ wt% Ni.

Step 2, the fractions. Each phase takes the arm on the side of the other phase:

$$W_L = \frac{S}{R+S} = \frac{43-35}{43-32} = \frac{8}{11} = 0.727 \qquad W_\alpha = \frac{R}{R+S} = \frac{35-32}{43-32} = \frac{3}{11} = 0.273$$

Step 3, checks. $W_L + W_\alpha = 8/11 + 3/11 = 1$. The nickel of the two phases adds up to the nickel of the alloy: $W_L C_L + W_\alpha C_\alpha = 0.727 \times 32 + 0.273 \times 43 = 23.27 + 11.73 = 35.0$ wt% Ni $= C_0$.

Answer. At 1250 °C the alloy is 73 % liquid of 32 wt% Ni and 27 % solid α of 43 wt% Ni. The alloy point is closer to the liquidus, so there is more liquid.

ROUNDING ON THE SLIDE

Slide 21 writes $W_L = 0.72$ and $W_\alpha = 0.28$. The exact values are $8/11 = 0.727$ and $3/11 = 0.273$, so they round to 0.73 and 0.27, as the official solutions of the problem sheet write them (Solution problems Phase diagrams I.pdf, p. 5). The slide truncates W_L and then takes $W_\alpha = 1 - W_L$.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4 — THE SAME ALLOY DURING EQUILIBRIUM COOLING [SESSION 7 SLIDE 23]

Slide 23 prints the equilibrium compositions of the liquid and the solid at several temperatures for the same Cu-35 wt% Ni alloy. Applying the lever rule at each one:

Point	C_L (wt% Ni)	C_α (wt% Ni)	$W_L = \frac{C_\alpha - C_0}{C_\alpha - C_L}$	W_α
b′ (liquidus)	35	46	$\frac{46-35}{46-35} = 1$	0
c′	29	40	$\frac{40-35}{40-29} = \frac{5}{11} = 0.455$	0.545
d′ (solidus)	24	35	$\frac{35-35}{35-24} = 0$	1

Interpretation. At b′ the first solid appears, of 46 wt% Ni, in a liquid that still has the composition of the alloy. As the temperature falls both phases become poorer in Ni (the liquid follows the liquidus, the solid follows the solidus) and the amount of solid grows. At d′ the solid has reached the composition of the alloy, 35 wt% Ni, and the last liquid disappears: in equilibrium, solidification ends on the solidus.

§ 7 Non-equilibrium solidification [Session 7 Slides 23-24]

When the alloy goes down through the phase diagram too quickly (high cooling rates), solid-state diffusion has no time to keep the whole solid at the equilibrium composition. Only the surface of each growing crystal has the composition of the solidus; the inside keeps the composition it had when it formed. The result is a microstructure of **heterogeneous composition**, called **microsegregation** (or **cored structure**).

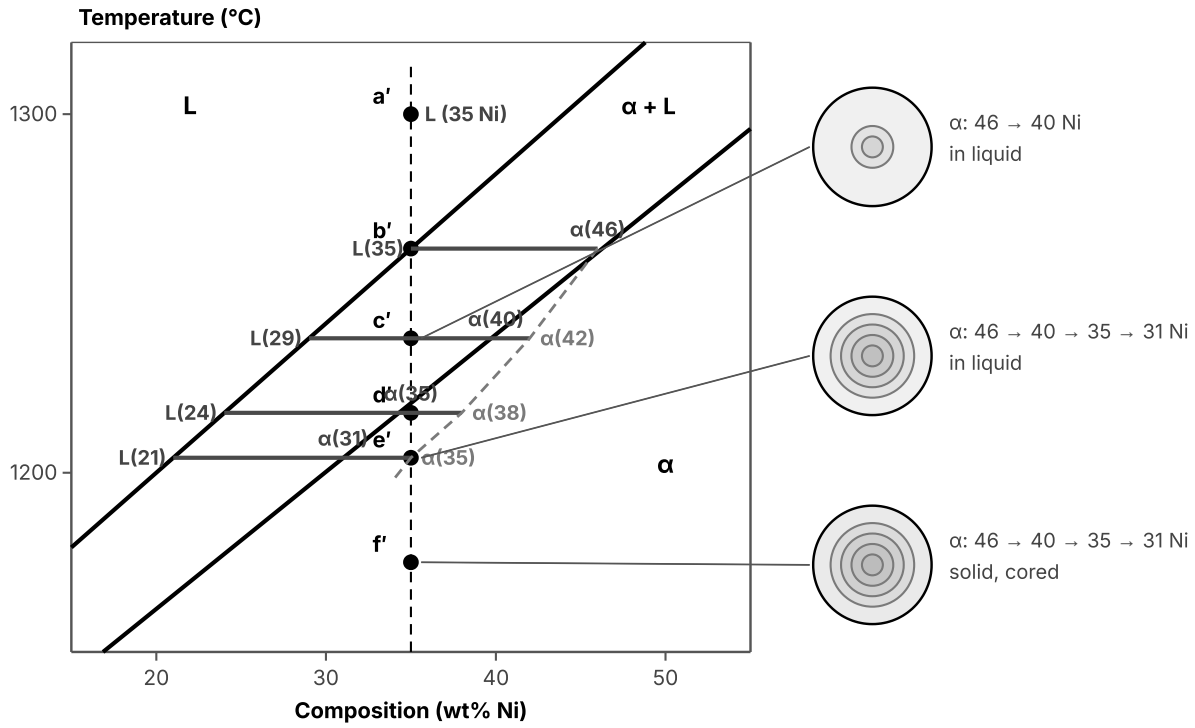


Figure 13. Fast cooling of Cu-35 wt% Ni: at each temperature only the surface of the growing crystals reaches the equilibrium composition (blue tie lines), so the average composition of the solid (dashed line) stays richer in Ni: 42 instead of 40 at c′, 38 instead of 35 at d′. Liquid remains below the equilibrium solidus and the grains end up cored, from 46 % Ni at the centre to 31 % Ni at the edge. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 23.

In the Cu-35 wt% Ni alloy the first solid is α of 46 wt% Ni (b′). At c′ the new layer is α of 40 wt% Ni, but the crystal still has its 46 % core, so its **average** composition is 42 wt% Ni instead of 40; at d′ the average is 38 instead of 35; at e′ it is 35. The average compositions follow a **non-equilibrium solidus** (dashed) that lies to the right of the equilibrium solidus, so liquid survives below the equilibrium solidus and solidification ends only at e′. The final grains are cored: 46 wt% Ni at the centre and 31 wt% Ni at the edge (f′).

The same behaviour in an alloy of Ni-30 wt% Cu (Slide 24): with fast cooling the solid follows the non-equilibrium solidus α'_2 … α'_7 and solidification ends at T_7 instead of T_5:

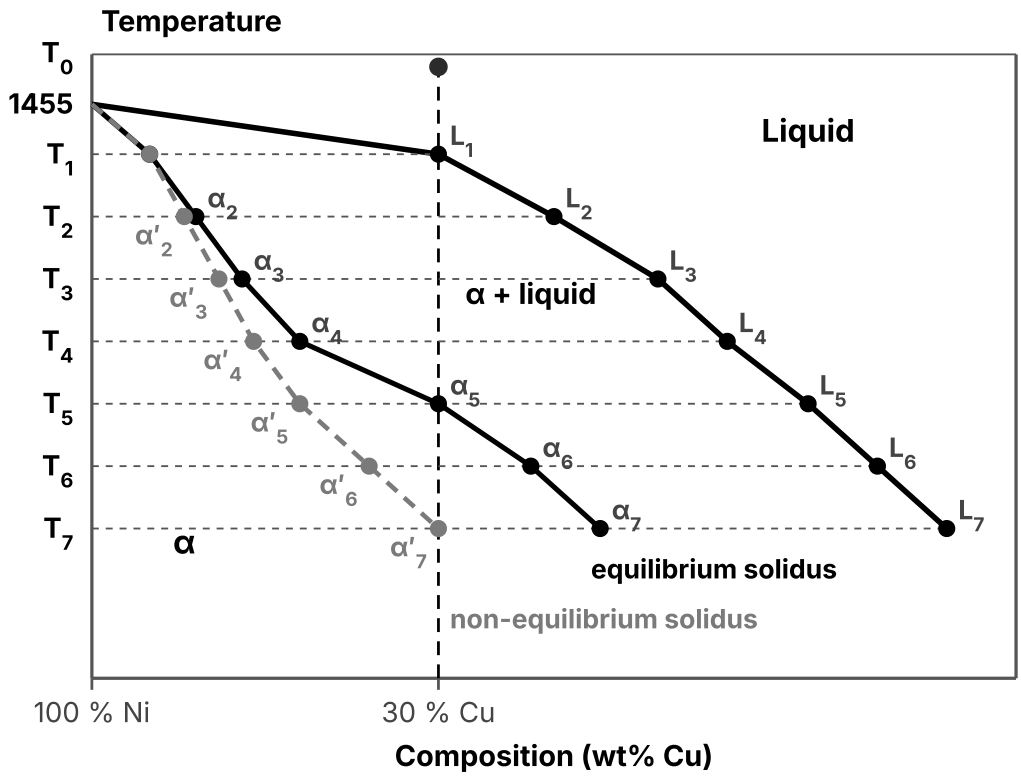


Figure 14. Ni-30 wt% Cu cooled from T_0: in equilibrium the solid follows α_1 ... α_5 and solidification ends at T_5; with fast cooling the average composition of the solid follows α'_2 ... α'_7 (non-equilibrium solidus) and solidification ends only at T_7. Schematic redrawn from Session 7 Slide 24.

Cored crystals growing in the liquid at T2 and T4

Figure 15. Cored crystals of the Ni-30 % Cu alloy growing in the liquid at T_2 and T_4: each new layer (α'_1, α'_2, ...) has a different composition. From Session 7 Slide 24.

Micrograph of a cored structure

Figure 16. Micrograph of a cored (microsegregated) structure: the rings in each grain are layers of different composition. From Session 7 Slide 24.

Removing the coring. Microsegregation can be eliminated with a **homogenisation heat treatment** at a temperature below the solidus (for example $T_{TT} < T_7$, below the lowest temperature at which liquid could exist). During the treatment, solid-state diffusion (Topic 3) evens out the composition inside the grains [Session 7 Slide 24].

WORKED EXAMPLE 5 — HOW MUCH LIQUID IS LEFT AT D′ WITH FAST COOLING [SESSION 7 SLIDE 23]

Data from the slide. At d′ the liquid is C_L = 24 wt% Ni, and the average composition of the cored solid is 38 wt% Ni (the dashed line). The alloy is C_0 = 35 wt% Ni.

Lever rule on the average composition. The tie line now ends on the non-equilibrium solidus, at 38 wt% Ni:

$$W_L = \frac{38 - 35}{38 - 24} = \frac{3}{14} = 0.214 \qquad W_\alpha = \frac{35 - 24}{38 - 24} = \frac{11}{14} = 0.786$$

Comparison. In equilibrium (Worked example 4) the alloy is completely solid at d′. With fast cooling about 21 % of the alloy is still liquid there; solidification ends only at e′, where the average composition of the solid reaches 35 wt% Ni and $W_L = (35 - 35)/(35 - 21) = 0$. The slide gives the average compositions; the lever rule is used here with them exactly as in §6.

§ 8 Binary eutectic systems [Session 7 Slides 26-32]

8.1 Partial solid solubility and the eutectic reaction [Session 7 Slides 26-27]

When the two components have only **partial solid solubility**, two solid solutions appear: α, rich in A, and β, rich in B. Their regions are bounded by three kinds of line:

- the **liquidus**, above which everything is liquid;
- the **solidus**, below which there is no liquid;
- the **solvus**, which gives the maximum solubility of B in α (and of A in β) at each temperature in the solid state.

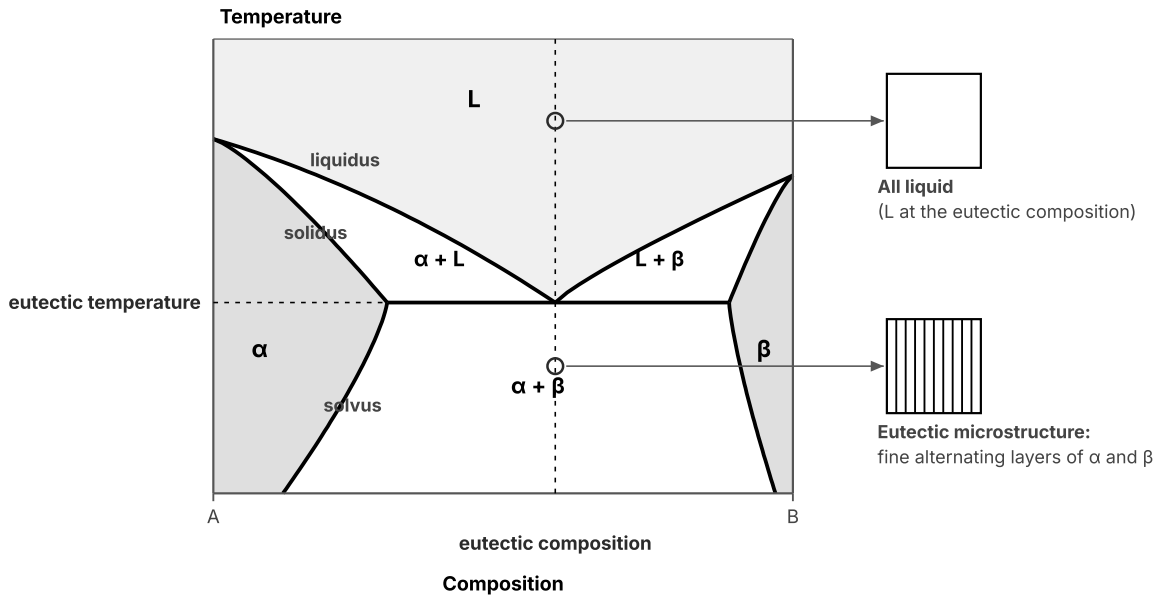


Figure 17. Two components with partial solid solubility and an invariant eutectic reaction: the liquidus, solidus and solvus lines bound the regions L, α, β, α + L, L + β and α + β; the liquid of eutectic composition solidifies at the eutectic temperature into fine alternating layers of α and β. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 26.

The two liquidus lines meet at the **eutectic point**, defined by the **eutectic temperature** and the **eutectic composition**. A liquid of eutectic composition does not pass through a two-phase L + solid region: at the eutectic temperature it transforms at once into **two** solids, in a fine microstructure of alternating layers of α and β.

Invariant reactions are produced at a fixed composition and a fixed temperature for a given system, and the result also remains fixed. In a system of two partially soluble components, a solidification reaction occurs at a fixed composition and temperature, with a cooling curve similar to that of a pure solid [Session 7 Slide 27]. This is the **eutectic reaction**:

$$L \rightarrow \alpha + \beta \quad \text{(on cooling, at the eutectic temperature)}$$

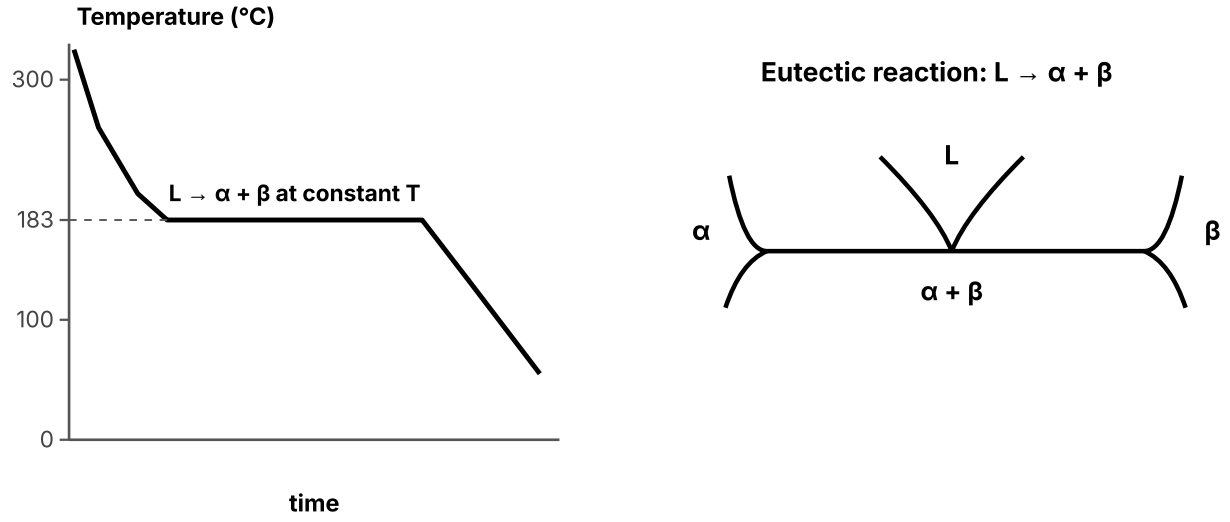


Figure 18. Left: the eutectic alloy solidifies at a single temperature (183 °C for Pb-Sn), with a thermal arrest like a pure metal. Right: around the eutectic point, the liquid L transforms into the two solids α and β. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 27.

With the phase rule of §5 at 1 atm: at the eutectic point three phases (L, α, β) coexist in a two-component system, so $F = 2 - 3 + 1 = 0$. Temperature and the compositions of the three phases are all fixed, which is why the reaction is invariant and the cooling curve shows a plateau.

8.2 The Pb-Sn system and the eutectic microstructure [Session 7 Slides 28-29]

The Pb-Sn diagram is the example of the slides. Its eutectic point is at **61.9 wt% Sn and 183 °C**. At 183 °C, α can dissolve at most **18.3 wt% Sn** and β contains **97.8 wt% Sn** [Session 7 Slide 32]. The melting points of the pure metals are 327 °C (Pb) and 232 °C (Sn) (Problems T4_PhaseDiagrams I.pdf, p. 1).

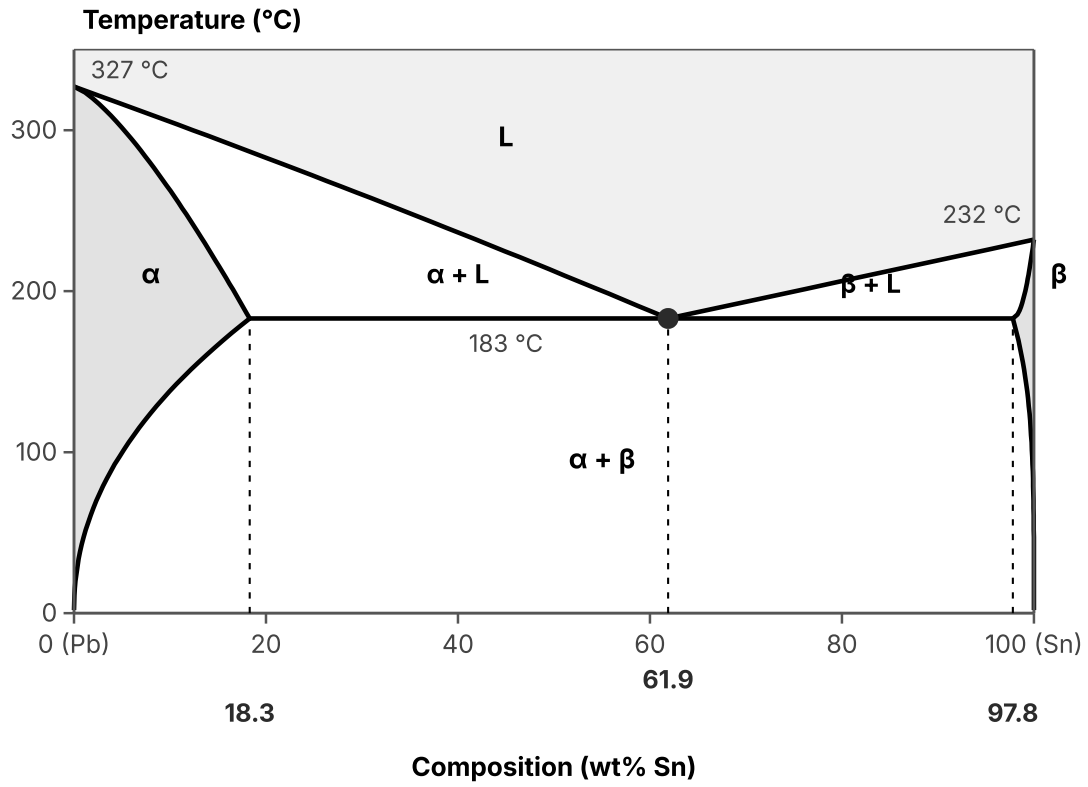


Figure 19. Pb-Sn diagram: eutectic point at 61.9 wt% Sn and 183 °C; at that temperature the maximum solubility is 18.3 wt% Sn in α (Pb-rich) and the β phase (Sn-rich) contains 97.8 wt% Sn. Melting points 327 °C (Pb) and 232 °C (Sn). Redrawn from Session 7 Slides 28 and 32.

A liquid of 61.9 wt% Sn, cooled to 183 °C, forms colonies of α and β layers that grow together into the liquid until the whole structure is eutectic (the **eutectic product**). The layers alternate with a spacing λ:



Eutectic forming from the liquid in Pb-Sn

Figure 20. Pb-Sn eutectic: layers of α and β grow together from the liquid of 61.9 % Sn (top) until the whole structure is eutectic colonies (bottom). From Session 7 Slide 28.



Lamellae of the eutectic product

Figure 21. The eutectic product: alternating lamellae of α and β; λ is the spacing of the layers. From Session 7 Slide 28.



Micrograph of the Pb-Sn eutectic

Figure 22. Micrograph of the Pb-Sn eutectic (scale bar 40 μm): dark and light layers are the two phases. From Session 7 Slide 28.

The shape of the eutectic changes from one system to another: rods, plates, globules or needles of one phase in the other.



Eutectic microstructures of four alloys

Figure 23. Eutectic microstructures: (a) Sn-50 % In, (b) Al-13 % Si, (c) Al-33 % Cu, (d) Mg-37 % Sn. From Session 7 Slide 29.

PB-SN VALUES IN THE PROBLEM SHEET

The diagram printed in the problem sheet (Problems T4_PhaseDiagrams I.pdf, p. 1) and the official solutions use 19.2 wt% Sn for α and 97.5 wt% Sn for β at 183 °C, instead of the 18.3 and 97.8 of Slide 32: they come from a different drawing of the same system. The worked examples of this page use the slide values; the solved problems use the values of the sheet.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6 — PHASES IN THE PB-SN EUTECTIC PRODUCT [SESSION 7 SLIDES 28 , 32]

Question. A Pb-61.9 wt% Sn alloy (eutectic composition) is cooled just below 183 °C. What are the amounts of α and β in the eutectic?

Tie line. Just below 183 °C the tie line crosses the α + β region from C_α = 18.3 to C_β = 97.8 wt% Sn; its length is $97.8 - 18.3 = 79.5$ wt% Sn.

Lever rule.

$$W_\alpha = \frac{C_\beta - C_0}{C_\beta - C_\alpha} = \frac{97.8 - 61.9}{97.8 - 18.3} = \frac{35.9}{79.5} = 0.452 \qquad W_\beta = \frac{C_0 - C_\alpha}{C_\beta - C_\alpha} = \frac{61.9 - 18.3}{79.5} = \frac{43.6}{79.5} = 0.548$$

Check. $0.452 + 0.548 = 1$ and $0.452 \times 18.3 + 0.548 \times 97.8 = 8.27 + 53.59 = 61.9$ wt% Sn $= C_0$.

Answer. The alloy is 100 % eutectic microconstituent, and inside it 45.2 % of the mass is α and 54.8 % is β. Every eutectic of this system, whatever the alloy it comes from, has these proportions (used in Worked example 7).

8.3 Hypoeutectic and hypereutectic alloys [Session 7 Slides 30-31]

An alloy between the α limit and the eutectic composition is **hypoeutectic**; one between the eutectic composition and the β limit is **hypereutectic**.

Hypoeutectic alloy (the slide uses Pb-Sn with about 30 wt% Sn, a reading of the figure):

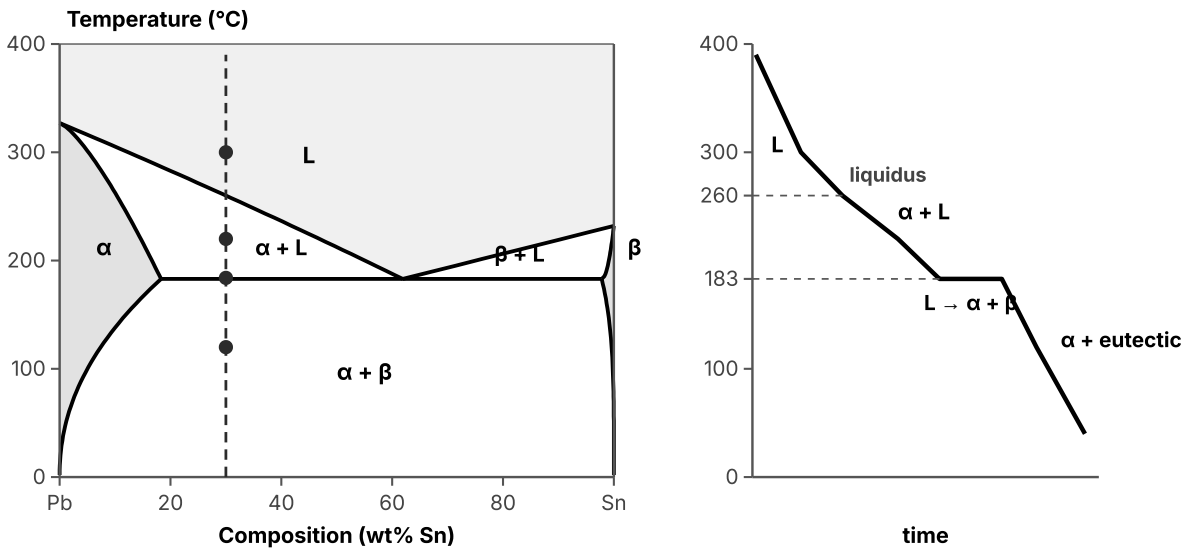


Figure 24. Hypoeutectic Pb-Sn alloy (dashed line, about 30 wt% Sn in the slide figure): primary α forms between the liquidus (260 °C on the cooling curve) and the eutectic temperature; at 183 °C the remaining liquid, now of eutectic composition, solidifies at constant temperature; the final structure is primary α plus eutectic. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 30.

1. Above the liquidus the alloy is liquid. The cooling curve shows the liquidus at 260 °C, where crystals of α start to form.
2. Between 260 and 183 °C, α and liquid coexist; α grows, and the liquid becomes richer in Sn along the liquidus.
3. Just above 183 °C the solid is α of about 19 wt% Sn and the liquid has reached the eutectic composition, 61.9 wt% Sn.
4. At 183 °C that liquid transforms at constant temperature into the eutectic ($L \rightarrow \alpha + \beta$): a plateau in the cooling curve.
5. Below 183 °C the structure is **primary (proeutectic) α** surrounded by **eutectic**.



Microstructure of a hypoeutectic Pb-Sn alloy during cooling

Figure 25. Hypoeutectic Pb-Sn alloy, from top to bottom: α crystals in the liquid; α of 19 % Sn in liquid of 61.9 % Sn just above the eutectic temperature; eutectic forming around the α; primary α in a eutectic matrix. From Session 7 Slide 30.



Micrograph of a hypoeutectic Pb-Sn alloy

Figure 26. Micrograph of a hypoeutectic Pb-Sn alloy: dark rounded primary α in the lamellar eutectic. From Session 7 Slide 30.

In a casting, the primary α grows from the mould wall, and the liquid trapped between the crystals is the last to solidify, with the eutectic composition:



Hypoeutectic solidification in a mould

Figure 27. Hypoeutectic solidification in a mould: primary α grows from the mould wall and the last liquid, between the crystals, reaches the eutectic composition. From Session 7 Slide 30.

Hypereutectic alloy: the same sequence with the roles of the solids exchanged. Primary β forms between the liquidus and the eutectic temperature, the remaining liquid gives the eutectic at the eutectic temperature, and the final structure is **primary β plus eutectic**.

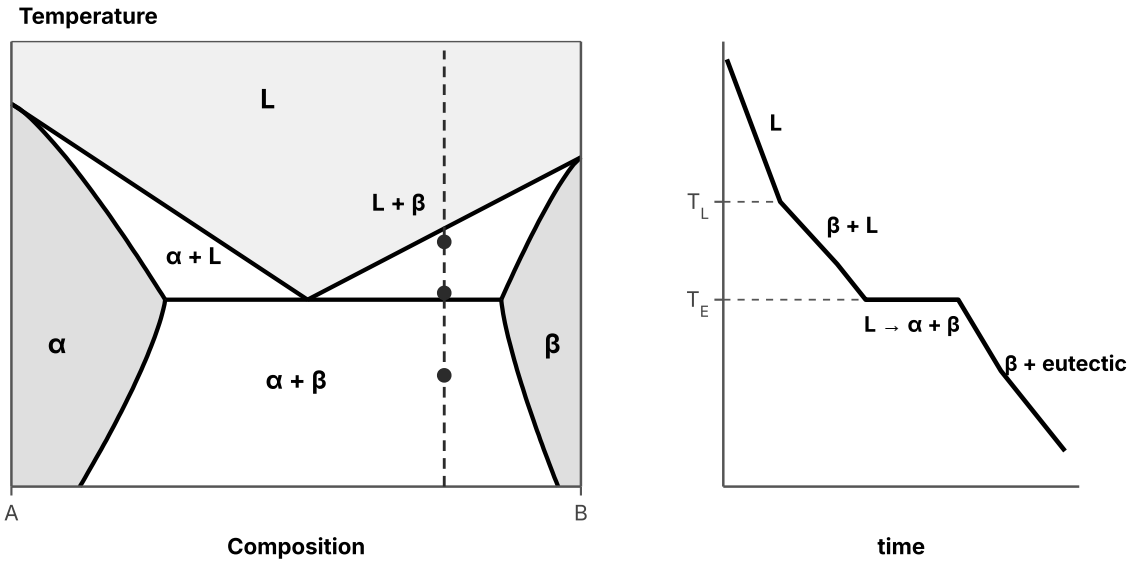


Figure 28. Hypereutectic alloy (dashed line, between the eutectic composition and the β limit): primary β forms between the liquidus T_L and the eutectic temperature T_E; at T_E the remaining liquid gives the eutectic; the final structure is primary β plus eutectic. Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 31.



Microstructure of a hypereutectic alloy during cooling

Figure 29. Hypereutectic alloy, from top to bottom: β crystals in the liquid; primary β just above the eutectic temperature; primary β in a eutectic matrix. From Session 7 Slide 31.



Micrograph of a hypereutectic alloy

Figure 30. Micrograph of a hypereutectic alloy: light rounded primary β in the eutectic. From Session 7 Slide 31.

(The cooling curve of Slide 31 repeats the temperature labels of the hypoeutectic curve, 260 and 183 °C; for a hypereutectic Pb-Sn alloy the liquidus is below 232 °C, so the curve is drawn here with generic labels T_L and T_E.)

8.4 Lever rule in binary eutectic diagrams [Session 7 Slide 32]

Just below the eutectic temperature, the tie line of a hypoeutectic alloy C'_4 is cut by the alloy and by the eutectic composition into three segments, P, Q and R:

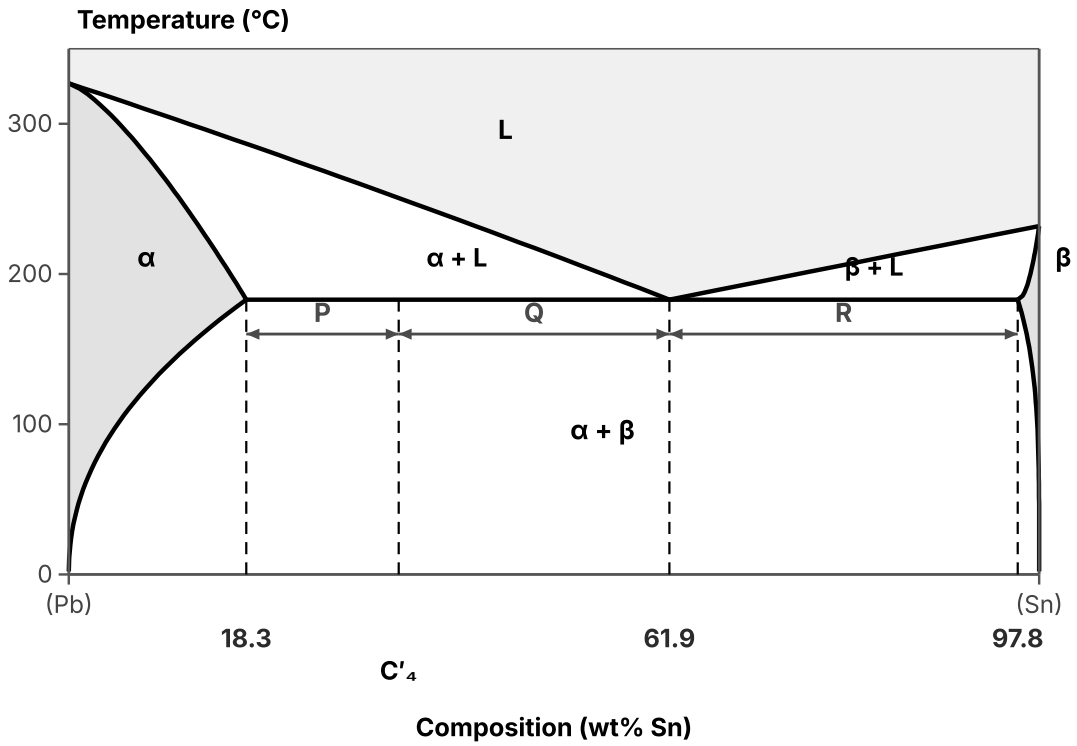


Figure 31. Just below the eutectic temperature the tie line runs from 18.3 to 97.8 wt% Sn. For an alloy C′₄ the segments P, Q and R give the fractions of primary α and eutectic (from P and Q) and of the phases α and β (from P + Q + R). Redrawn from Session 7 Slide 32.

$$W_{\alpha'} = \frac{Q}{P+Q} \qquad W_e = W_L = \frac{P}{P+Q} \qquad W_\alpha = \frac{Q+R}{P+Q+R} \qquad W_\beta = \frac{P}{P+Q+R}$$

- W_e: fraction of eutectic microconstituent, equal to W_L, the fraction of liquid just above the eutectic temperature (all that liquid becomes eutectic);
- $W_{\alpha'}$: fraction of α′ phase, the **primary** α;
- W_α: **total** fraction of α (primary α plus the α inside the eutectic);
- W_β: fraction of β phase (all of it inside the eutectic).

The first two use the short tie line between α and the eutectic liquid (microconstituents); the last two use the whole tie line between α and β (phases).

WORKED EXAMPLE 7 — MICROCONSTITUENTS AND PHASES OF PB-30 WT% SN [SESSION 7 SLIDES 30 , 32]

Data. Alloy C_0 = 30 wt% Sn (the hypoeutectic alloy of Slide 30), just below 183 °C, with the values of Slide 32: C_α = 18.3, C_e = 61.9, C_β = 97.8 wt% Sn.

Step 1, the segments. $P = C_0 - C_\alpha = 30 - 18.3 = 11.7$; $Q = C_e - C_0 = 61.9 - 30 = 31.9$; $R = C_\beta - C_e = 97.8 - 61.9 = 35.9$; so $P + Q = 43.6$ and $P + Q + R = 79.5$ (all in wt% Sn).

Step 2, microconstituents (short tie line, from α to the eutectic liquid):

$$W_{\alpha'} = \frac{Q}{P+Q} = \frac{31.9}{43.6} = 0.732 \qquad W_e = \frac{P}{P+Q} = \frac{11.7}{43.6} = 0.268$$

Step 3, phases (whole tie line, from α to β):

$$W_\alpha = \frac{Q+R}{P+Q+R} = \frac{67.8}{79.5} = 0.853 \qquad W_\beta = \frac{P}{P+Q+R} = \frac{11.7}{79.5} = 0.147$$

Step 4, the α inside the eutectic. It is the total α minus the primary α: $W_{\alpha,e} = W_\alpha - W_{\alpha'} = 0.853 - 0.732 = 0.121$.

Check, phases against microconstituents. By Worked example 6 every eutectic is 45.2 % α and 54.8 % β. Then $W_e \times 0.452 = 0.268 \times 0.452 = 0.121 = W_{\alpha,e}$ and $W_e \times 0.548 = 0.268 \times 0.548 = 0.147 = W_\beta$: both descriptions of the alloy agree.

Answer. Just below 183 °C the alloy is 73.2 % primary α and 26.8 % eutectic. Counting phases, it is 85.3 % α (73.2 % primary plus 12.1 % in the eutectic) and 14.7 % β. Just above 183 °C the same lever gives 73.2 % α of 18.3 wt% Sn and 26.8 % liquid of 61.9 wt% Sn: that liquid is what becomes the eutectic.